

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

THURSDAY 13 AUGUST 2026



SIGNAL & NOISE · THE PRINT THAT SOOTHED, THE SLEEP THAT MATTERED, THE BAND THAT WON'T DIE

TECHNOLOGY

Two thirty-billion brains land for a single 5090 in forty-eight hours — one fast, one clever

THE RABBIT HOLE

Shortwave: the band the broadcasters abandoned, and the hobby that refused to die with it

THE LONG READ

Japan's grown-ups are buying companionship you can carry — and posting it with their faces off

THIS ISSUE

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FROM THE DESK

"The signal is the truth. The noise is what distracts us from the truth."

— Nate Silver, *The Signal and the Noise* (2012)¹

The book runs on one distinction: the number everyone watches, and the thing that actually moves. Markets braced for a hot inflation print and got a mild one, yet gold rose on fear, not prices (p14). Parents fixate on screens; the research points at sleep (p12). A record land bid lands the same week as a falling flat (p6). And the hobby on p15 is the metaphor made literal — a band of static where the whole game is pulling the signal out.

THE STRIP — AT WEDNESDAY'S CLOSE

LEVEL	12 AUG
VWRA (All-World)	~\$194
US 10-Year	~4.65%
DXY	~99.8
USD/SGD	~1.280
USD/JPY	~159.3
Brent	~\$91.6
Gold (XAU)	~\$4,420
Bitcoin	~\$64.2k
STI	~5,712

Levels at the Tuesday/Wednesday US session; arrows show the week's direction. July US CPI came in mild — yields eased, gold firmed anyway (p14).²

THE THREAD — SIGNAL & NOISE

A working definition for the fortnight: the *signal* is what changes an outcome; the *noise* is the number, the headline, the ritual we mistake for it. Singapore's growth forecast doubled and the country asked why it couldn't feel it (p5). Fitness science found that the count of sessions mattered less than the dose inside them (p18). Even Kyiv's "proposals" are a signal held back — undisclosed, while the one number that governs the war, the map, doesn't move (p3). Read this issue for the difference.³

SOURCES 1 Nate Silver, *The Signal and the Noise: Why So Many Predictions Fail — but Some Don't* (Penguin, 2012) — the epigraph is the book's organising distinction. 2 US Bureau of Labor Statistics, CPI for July 2026, released 12 Aug 2026; market levels at the 12 Aug US session — CNBC; FXStreet; Yahoo Finance; TradingView (STI). 3 Issue spine — editorial.

THE WORLD • THE UNDISCLOSED PROPOSAL

Kyiv Hands Washington a Plan No One Will Read Aloud

Volodymyr Zelenskyy says Ukraine has "conveyed its proposals to the American side" and is ready for "all negotiation formats." The content stays sealed; the American envoys have not been to Kyiv since January; and the only number that governs the war — the map — has not moved a metre. A fresh diplomatic push, or the theatre of one.

The signal this week was a silence. On 11 August, in his nightly address, Zelenskyy said Kyiv had "conveyed our proposals to the American side" for ending the war and was "ready for all negotiation formats," pinning the effort to an August push by the US envoys Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner.¹ What the proposals contain, he did not say — and there lies the story. A plan announced but withheld is a plan meant to be seen wanting rather than read: it lets Kyiv look constructive to Washington without conceding an inch on the ground, and it dares Moscow to reject a document nobody outside the room has seen.¹ Around it, the war's actual coordinates were unchanged. Russia's terms, restated through the Kremlin, remain full Ukrainian withdrawal from Donetsk, Luhansk, Kherson and Zaporizhzhia, plus "the root causes" — the maximalist four-oblast demand it has held since June 2024.²

The mechanics undercut the momentum. Witkoff and Kushner were last in Moscow in January and have not travelled to Kyiv since; a Ukrainian drive that runs through American shuttle diplomacy needs the shuttle to actually run.¹ Meanwhile the fighting spoke plainly: Ukrainian drones struck an oil-refining city roughly 750 miles inside Russia, and a Moscow court barred the country's principal liberal, anti-war party from the September 2026 parliamentary elections — the domestic door to a negotiated settlement quietly closing as the diplomatic one is said to open.³ For a reader in Singapore the read-

through is narrow: no ceasefire means no near-term easing of the war-risk premium in energy and grain, and the "proposal" is worth exactly as much as its still-unpublished text.²

A plan announced but withheld is meant to be seen wanting, not read.

KYIV — VIA REUTERS / "WE CONVEYED OUR WIRES PROPOSALS"

The Western wire framing casts Ukraine as the constructive party: Zelenskyy asks Washington to "strengthen our defence ... and put pressure on Russia ... to prepare for an end to the war rather than prolonging it." Russia is the side dragging its feet.¹

MOSCOW — KREMLIN / TASS "A SETTLEMENT REMAINS PREFERABLE"

Dmitry Peskov: a "political and diplomatic settlement ... remains preferable for us" — then reverses the condition onto Kyiv. "Zelensky should order the armed forces to cease fire and leave" the four regions; "at this point, a ceasefire will come."²

DOHA — AL JAZEERA / "THE LAND QUESTION, NON-ALIGNED UNMOVED"

The non-aligned read foregrounds mechanism over morality: the unresolved land-for-peace swap, the stalled cadence of envoys, a process that has produced words but not a metre of agreed map. It assigns no blame, and expects little. (Summarised from coverage.)⁴

THE CHATTER — ANALYSTS READ THE OMISSION

The tell for the desk-watchers is the withholding: an undisclosed proposal costs Kyiv nothing and commits it to nothing — useful theatre before an American audience, not the shape of a deal. The steel-man is that a public text becomes a target for maximalists on both flanks, so secrecy can be a condition of seriousness, not its absence.¹

SOURCES 1 Zelenskyy nightly address, 11 Aug 2026 — Ukraine "conveyed proposals to the American side," "ready for all negotiation formats"; Witkoff/Kushner August push, envoys last in Moscow Jan 2026 — US News; Japan Times (12 Aug); RBC-Ukraine. 2 Kremlin / Dmitry Peskov via TASS — settlement "preferable," conditioned on Ukrainian withdrawal from Donetsk/Luhansk/Kherson/Zaporizhzhia; maximalist demand unchanged since Jun 2024 — TASS. 3 Ukrainian drone strike ~750 mi inside Russia; Moscow court bars the main anti-war party from the Sept 2026 Duma elections — US News; Ukrainska Pravda; wires. 4 Non-aligned framing — Al Jazeera / regional wires; characterised from coverage, not a verbatim quote — flagged.

THE WORLD · TWO SIGNALS, READ CAREFULLY

Turkey Pardons the PKK — On a Condition That Hasn't Been Met

Parliament voted 468 to 88 for a conditional amnesty covering thousands of Kurdish fighters — but it triggers only when authorities verify full disarmament, which hasn't happened. A gesture with a switch that no one has flipped.

The vote was lopsided and the fine print decisive. On 10–11 August the Turkish parliament passed, 468 to 88, a conditional pardon for thousands of PKK militants — but the law takes effect only after the state confirms the group's full disarmament.¹ It follows the PKK's 2025 self-dissolution, called by its jailed leader Abdullah Öcalan, and a symbolic laying-down of weapons in northern Iraq. The PKK-linked news agency called the law a "beginning" with "serious shortcomings," and demanded Öcalan's release. The signal is the condition, not the headline: an amnesty no one can yet claim is a promise, not a fact.

The week's other running story advanced grimly. Colombia's magnitude-7.4 earthquake of 10 August — ~110 km down, near San José del Palmar in Chocó — kept climbing the count this desk logged last issue at

roughly 130 to 170 dead. By 12 August the toll had passed 250, with more than 570 injured and official "missing" figures diverging sharply from civilian trackers; 61 buildings collapsed and a Cali hospital's paediatric wing came down.² The lesson is caution: with a national disaster declared in a mountainous epicentre, every figure is provisional, and the gap between government and civilian counts is itself the point.²

468–88

THE MARGIN FOR A CONDITIONAL PKK AMNESTY — BUT THE PARDON TRIGGERS ONLY ON VERIFIED, FULL DISARMAMENT, NOT YET CERTIFIED. A SWITCH INSTALLED, NOT FLIPPED.¹

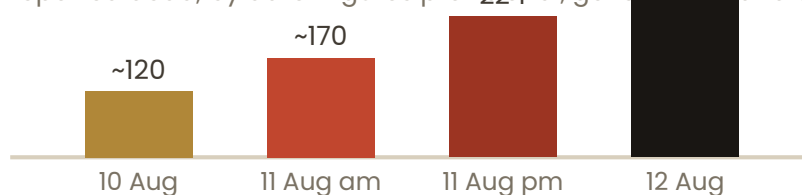
UKRAINE · SEALED PROPOSAL

TURKEY · CONDITIONAL PARDON

COLOMBIA · TOLL RISING

Colombia quake — the count that kept moving

reported dead, by date · figures provisional, government and civilian



A Meridian chart. Reported fatalities, Colombia M7.4 earthquake — a rising, provisional count. Source: CNN; NBC; Al Jazeera; USGS event us6000tjl2.

THE SCEPTIC — BEWARE THE ROUND NUMBER IN A DISASTER

The disciplined reading of both stories is to distrust the clean figure. A "468–88" amnesty reads as resolution but resolves nothing until disarmament is certified; a rising death toll invites a single headline number when the honest answer is a range with a widening error bar.¹ What would falsify the optimistic read on Turkey: the pardon left uncertified into 2027, or Öcalan's detention hardening the PKK's "shortcomings" into a walk-back.²

IN BRIEF — AROUND THE DESKS

Washington. A Boston federal judge blocked the US Postal Service from enforcing part of an executive order

tightening mail-in voting rules before November's elections.³

Moscow. A court barred Russia's main liberal anti-war party from the

September 2026 Duma elections — the settlement's domestic constituency shut out of the vote.³

SOURCES 1 Turkish parliament vote, 10–11 Aug 2026 — 468–88 conditional PKK pardon, effective on verified full disarmament; PKK-linked ANF calls it a "beginning" with "serious shortcomings," demands Öcalan's release — NPR; NBC; KPBS. 2 Colombia M7.4 earthquake, 10 Aug 2026, depth ~110 km, Chocó; toll ~120 (10 Aug) → 224 (11 Aug) → 250+ (12 Aug), 570+ injured, 61 buildings collapsed, Cali hospital paediatric wing down — CNN; NBC; ABC; Al Jazeera; USGS us6000tjl2. 3 USPS mail-in-voting order partially blocked (Boston federal court); Russia's main anti-war party barred from Sept 2026 elections — wires. 4 Gulf one-line delta — US-brokered Gaza track reported collapsed ~10–11 Aug; Iran ties Hormuz reopening to reparations; no fresh resolution — wires (not a lead, per continuity).

SINGAPORE • THE BOOM YOU CAN'T FEEL

The Forecast Doubled. The Question Is Why Nobody Noticed.

On 11 August the Trade Ministry more than doubled its 2026 growth forecast to 4.5–5.5%, on an AI-driven electronics-export surge that pushed non-oil exports up 27% in the quarter. It is a genuine boom — and it is landing in a country where retrenchments are rising and the resale flat is falling. The gap between the print and the pavement is where this desk sits.

The number was enormous and strangely weightless. On 11 August the Ministry of Trade and Industry lifted its full-year 2026 GDP forecast to 4.5–5.5%, up from the 2.0–4.0% range set in May, citing an acceleration in global AI-related capital spending; the same morning Enterprise Singapore raised its non-oil domestic export forecast to 14–16%, from 3–5%.¹ The engine is narrow and white-hot: second-quarter GDP rose 5.9% year on year, manufacturing 12.5%, and electronic exports an extraordinary 88% — integrated circuits alone up more than 90% — as the world's chip build-out routes demand through Singapore's fabs and ports.² This is the signal. The noise around it is the mood: a boom concentrated in trade-exposed electronics and pharmaceuticals, felt in the export statistics and almost nowhere a household shops.

The gap has political weight three weeks before the National Day Rally. Second-quarter retrenchments climbed to roughly 4,500, from 3,830 in the first quarter, as outward-facing firms restructured even

while employment kept expanding; on 5 August a manpower minister told Parliament that unions and employers would be consulted before any decision to legislate retrenchment benefits — a step short of the Workers' Party's call to legislate, and past the earlier "major review" holding line.³ In his National Day Message, Prime Minister Lawrence Wong promised a "major review" of family support — child-raising costs, affordable infant and childcare — with details deferred to the Rally on 23 August.⁴ For a comfortable reader, the read-through is that the Treasury plainly has room; the test on the 23rd is whether a record growth year converts into recurring relief that changes a behaviour, or one-offs that flatter a Budget and fade.

+88%

GROWTH IN SINGAPORE'S ELECTRONIC EXPORTS IN Q2, INTEGRATED CIRCUITS UP MORE THAN 90% — THE AI-CHIP SURGE THAT DOUBLED THE OFFICIAL GROWTH FORECAST. THE BOOM IS REAL; IT IS ALSO ALMOST ENTIRELY IN THE EXPORT COLUMN.²

GDP 4.5–5.5%

NODX 14–16%

RALLY: 23 AUG

THE CHATTER — "GROWTH WE DON'T FEEL"

The comment-carrying coverage and the local forums converge on one line under every blockbuster print: headline GDP up, cost-of-living and job security unchanged — "growth we don't feel."⁵ Nomura's read called the upgrade "massive," and it is; but the same fortnight carried an opposition leader, Peoples Voice's Lim Tean, arrested on 11 August after failing to surrender to begin a jail term and being repatriated from Johor Bahru — a reminder that the political weather is not all sunshine and semiconductors.⁶

THE SCEPTIC — A NARROW BOOM ON A HIGH BASE

Don't extrapolate the 5.9%. It is an AI-electronics-and-pharma spike on a concentrated base; economists warn of high-base drag in the second half, with one house pencilling quarter-on-quarter growth of just ~0.5% in Q3 and Q4, and consumer-facing sectors still lagging.² The falsifier for the "boom" narrative is a Rally that answers "stretched households" with another round of vouchers, or an H2 slowdown that turns a doubled forecast into a first-half memory. The receipt to watch is the 23rd — a number attached to family support, or a deferral to Budget 2027.⁴

SOURCES 1 MTI, "MTI Upgrades 2026 GDP Growth Forecast to 4.5 to 5.5 Per Cent," 11 Aug 2026; Enterprise Singapore NODX forecast raised to 14–16% (from 3–5%) — MTI newsroom; CNBC (11 Aug); Bloomberg. 2 Q2 2026 GDP +5.9% y/y (manufacturing +12.5%, wholesale +8.3%); Q2 NODX +27.4%, electronic NODX +88.1%, ICs +91.9%; economists flag high-base H2 drag — MTI; EnterpriseSG; Xinhua roundup (12 Aug); Nomura. 3 Q2 retrenchments ~4,500 (Q1 3,830); MOS (Manpower) Dinesh Vasu Dash, Parliament 5 Aug — unions/employers to be consulted before legislating retrenchment benefits — Yahoo News SG; WP.sg. 4 PM Wong National Day Message, 9 Aug 2026 — "major review" of family support, details at the National Day Rally, 23 Aug — PMO; Mothership; Malay Mail. 5 Community read — comment-carrying coverage and r/singapore, "growth we don't feel"; characterised, not verbatim — flagged. 6 Lim Tean (Peoples Voice) arrested 11 Aug 2026 on repatriation from Johor Bahru after failing to surrender to begin his sentence — SPF media release; Malay Mail.

PROPERTY · TWO SIGNALS, ONE FORTNIGHT

A Record Land Bid and a Falling Flat, in the Same Week

The state awarded the Bayshore Drive site at S\$1,323 per square foot — the highest land rate ever paid outside the central region. Days later, the July HDB resale flash showed prices falling for a second straight quarter even as volume hit a 2026 high. Confidence at the top, softening in the middle: for an owner weighing the exit, both are the market.

Read the two prints together and the market resolves into a divergence, not a direction. The URA award of the Bayshore Drive mixed-use site went to a Frasers-led consortium at S\$2.128 billion, or S\$1,323 per square foot of gross floor area — a record land rate for a site outside the Core Central Region, for up to ~1,280 homes plus a mall over the Bedok South station.¹ Three bids, the top three within about 7%: competitive, not frenzied, and a developer vote of confidence in the eastern fringe. That is the top-of-market signal. The middle of the market sent the opposite. The July HDB resale flash showed prices down about 0.7% on the month — a second straight quarterly fall on the resale index — even as transaction volume jumped to a 2026 high of ~2,660, with 27 flats crossing a million dollars.²

For an owner weighing an early-retirement exit, the two signals cut in different directions and both matter. The record land rate implies eventual launch pricing likely in the S\$2,600–3,000-plus range, which

resets the benchmark upward for nearby East Coast resale — supportive of a landed or older-condo seller in the east.¹ But a resale index falling two quarters running, against a 12,000-home Bayshore precinct pipeline, says the days of banking on runaway capital gains are over: liquidity is fine, the price is not rising.² The New Upper Changi Road plot this desk flagged last issue — ~1,010 units fronting Bedok MRT — still has its tender open to 1 September; that result is the next real read on whether the eastern pipeline is a ceiling or a floor.³

S\$1,323

PER SQUARE FOOT OF GROSS FLOOR AREA FOR THE BAYSHORE DRIVE SITE — THE HIGHEST EVER PAID AT A GOVERNMENT LAND SALES TENDER OUTSIDE THE CENTRAL REGION. A CONFIDENCE SIGNAL AT THE TOP, LANDING THE SAME WEEK THE MASS-MARKET RESALE INDEX FELL AGAIN.¹

BAYSHORE AWARDED

HDB RESALE -0.7%

NEW UPPER CHANGI: 1 SEP

THE CHATTER — WHO ABSORBS 1,280 UNITS AND A MALL?

On the property forums and the EdgeProp comment threads, the record quantum drew the obvious question: who absorbs 1,280 homes plus retail in one precinct, and does an "integrated development" premium survive a two-quarter resale decline? The bull read is that scarcity of large east-coast sites justifies the rate; the bear read is that three bids, down from the frenzy of earlier cycles, reads as caution priced as confidence.¹

THE SCEPTIC — A LAND RECORD IS A FORWARD BET, NOT A FLOOR

A record psf is a developer's forecast, not a homeowner's guarantee. The land rate prices in launch demand three to four years out; between now and then sit a falling resale index, a heavy east-side pipeline, and cooling measures that have already capped the reflexive central-region bid (Dunearn House cleared 56% at launch, not the ~99% the market once assumed).⁴ The falsifier for the bullish read is the 1 September New Upper Changi tender coming in soft, or Bayshore's own eventual launch pricing landing below the ~S\$2,700 psf the land rate implies. This is not investment advice; it is what two opposite prints are actually saying.³

SOURCES 1 URA award, Bayshore Drive mixed-use GLS — Frasers-led consortium (Frasers Property/FCT/Sunway/Sekisui House/Lum Chang), S\$2.128bn, S\$1,323 psf ppr, record OCR land rate; ~1,280 units + retail, over Bedok South MRT; 3 bids — URA; EdgeProp SG; CBRE commentary. 2 July 2026 HDB resale flash — prices ~-0.7% m/m (2nd straight quarterly fall on the RPI), volume ~2,660 (2026 high, +24.5% m/m), 27 million-dollar flats — 99.co/SRX flash; EdgeProp SG; PropNex. 3 New Upper Changi Rd GLS ~1,010 units fronting Bedok MRT — tender closes 1 Sep 2026 (HELD) — URA Confirmed List. 4 Dunearn House (Turf City) — 56% (212/380) at launch weekend, avg ~S\$3,140 psf, 3-bedders sold out — 99.co; EdgeProp; Stacked Homes. Not investment advice.

TECHNOLOGY · TWO BRAINS, ONE CARD

A Speed King and an Accuracy King, Both Sized for the Card You Own

In forty-eight hours, NVIDIA and Meta each shipped a thirty-billion-parameter open model built to run on a single consumer GPU. Nemotron 3.5 Lightning is the fastest thing on the bench; Muse Glimmer is the sharpest. The community verdict is already written — and it is not "which is best," but "which is best for what."

The home lab got two new engines in one week, and they answer different questions. On 11 August NVIDIA released Nemotron 3.5 Lightning 30B-A3B — a 30-billion-parameter mixture-of-experts model with just 3 billion active, an interleaved Mamba-2-plus-MoE design, up to a million tokens of context, and, tellingly, a native NVFP4 checkpoint for Blackwell shipped alongside day-one GGUF for llama.cpp, Ollama and LM Studio.¹ It is built for throughput: independent testing clocked it near 1,200 tokens a second, and NVIDIA's own numbers claim it completes agentic tasks around 30% faster than a comparable Qwen at similar accuracy.¹ A day earlier, Meta's Superintelligence Labs had released Muse Glimmer — roughly 29.6 billion parameters, dense rather than sparse, multimodal, Apache-2.0 — distilled from its larger Muse Spark and posting the higher accuracy numbers of the pair (an AIME 2026 of 94.7, SWE-bench Verified 76.0), while trailing on some agentic and long-context tests.²

The distinction that matters to a single-card owner is not the leaderboard but the shape of the work. A hands-on that ran four new 30B models through twelve hard problems on an RTX 5090 reached the verdict the whole community has settled on:

Glimmer scored the "perfect, most-efficient thinking," but is the slowest generator and slows further on long context; Nemotron is the throughput champion whose best numbers are the ones NVIDIA most wants you to see.³ Put plainly — Glimmer if your card is 24GB, you want vision, and you value headroom; Nemotron if your work lives in long documents and you want speed.³ Both are execution-grade tools, not frontier reasoners, and both fit the machine on the desk. That is the real news: the interesting models now come to the hardware you already own.

The interesting models now come to the hardware you already own — the question stopped being "can I run it" and became "which one, for what."

~1,200

TOKENS PER SECOND MEASURED FOR NEMOTRON 3.5 LIGHTNING — THE "SPEED KING." MUSE GLIMMER ANSWERS HARDER PROBLEMS MORE ACCURATELY BUT GENERATES FAR SLOWER. SAME CARD, OPPOSITE VIRTUES.³

NEMOTRON 3.5 LIGHTNING

MUSE GLIMMER 30B

OPEN WEIGHTS · SINGLE-GPU

THE CHATTER — R/LOCALLLAMA AND HACKER NEWS SPLIT BY USE-CASE

Two Hacker News threads landed on the same note the subreddit did: enthusiasm for "small and efficient over massive," tempered by a recurring skeptic line that Nemotron "looks behind the Qwen equivalent on most benchmarks."¹ The community's practical wisdom, repeated across the quant threads: keep Glimmer for the hard, correctness-critical prompts and vision; keep Nemotron loaded for the long-context, high-volume grind. Nobody is arguing there's one winner — the argument is about the workload.³

SOURCES ¹ NVIDIA Nemotron 3.5 Lightning 30B-A3B, released 11 Aug 2026 — 30B/3B-active MoE, Mamba-2 + MoE, up to 1M context, NVFP4 + day-one GGUF, ~1,200 tok/s (Artificial Analysis), OpenMDW-1.1; HN threads note it "behind the Qwen equivalent" on some benchmarks — Artificial Analysis; NVIDIA Technical Blog; MarkTechPost (11 Aug); Hacker News. ² Meta Muse Glimmer 30B, released 10 Aug 2026 — ~29.6B dense multimodal, Apache-2.0, distilled from Muse Spark; AIME 2026 94.7, SWE-bench Verified 76.0 (vendor-published, no independent eval — flagged) — MarkTechPost (10 Aug); NVIDIA Technical Blog; Unsloth. ³ KGP Talkie, "I Ran 4 New 30B Models Through 12 Hard Problems on an RTX 5090" (Aug 2026) — Glimmer most accurate/slowest, Nemotron fastest; verdict "Glimmer for 24GB + vision, Nemotron for long context" — kgptalkie.com.

THE HOME LAB • WHAT YOUR CARD ACTUALLY RUNS

One 5090 for the Daily Driver; Two for the Full-Fat Build

Both models were designed against a VRAM ladder that reads like a spec sheet for this reader's rig. The single-card path is the four-bit GGUF; the dual-card path buys back full precision, vision and headroom. And the chip that makes all of this scarce just raised its capex again.

The VRAM ladder is where the abstraction meets the desk. Muse Glimmer's four-bit K-quant lands at about 16.8GB — comfortable on a 24GB card — with an optional 1.4GB vision projector and a small draft model that, with speculative decoding, lifts throughput on an RTX 5090 from roughly 75 to 233 tokens a second, a 3.1× jump.¹ Meta's targets read as a ladder: 24GB for the quantised daily driver, 64GB for full precision plus vision — precisely the case for a dual-5090 build. Nemotron's four-bit GGUF is about 25GB, sitting neatly on the 5090's 32GB; its NVFP4 build wants TensorRT-LLM or vLLM, so on Windows the practical single-card route is GGUF through Ollama, and a two-card, 64GB rig buys back the long-context headroom.² The reader's question — "what runs on my machine?" — now has a precise answer: one card runs them; two run them properly.

The scarcity underneath deepened. On 9–10 August TSMC reported July revenue of US\$14.5 billion, up

45% year on year, lifted full-year growth guidance above 40%, and raised 2026 capex to US\$60–64 billion, its chairman calling AI demand "extremely robust."³ The read-through for the home lab is unglamorous but real: new fab capacity lands on an 18-to-24-month lag, so the advanced-node crunch — and the tight supply of Blackwell-class cards — persists through 2026.

3.1×

THROUGHPUT GAIN FOR MUSE GLIMMER ON A 5090 WITH SPECULATIVE DECODING — ABOUT 75 TO 233 TOKENS A SECOND. ONE CARD RUNS IT; THE TRICK IS SQUEEZING MORE OUT.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF — THE HELD THREAD

Qwen3.8-27B / Qwen3.8-Max open weights — still unshipped. Promised "during the week of 10 August"; as of filing neither had appeared and no licence was named. A community FP8 repo is not the official drop. Graded 17 August.⁴

The VRAM ladder — where each build fits

approx. weight size, four-bit / K-quant · single 5090 = 32GB · dual !

Muse Glimmer 4-bit — ~16.8GB

Nemotron 3.5 4-bit GGUF — ~25GB

Glimmer full precision + vision — ~64GB (dual 5090)

24GB 32GB · one 5090

A Meridian chart. Approx. weight sizes vs the 5090's 32GB and a dual-5090's 64GB. Source: Unsloth; NVIDIA Technical Blog; bartowski GGUF cards.

THE SCEPTIC — THE BENCHMARK YOU'RE SHOWN VS THE ONE THAT SHIPS

Every headline number here is vendor-published on a model card; there is, as yet, no independent evaluation of Glimmer's 94.7 AIME, and Meta's preparedness section self-rates "moderate or lower" risk without publishing the red-team detail.⁵ Nemotron's flattering figures — tokens per second, a proprietary agentic benchmark — are the ones NVIDIA most wants in the frame; its raw reasoning trails the Qwen it is measured against.¹ The falsifier is simple and dated: independent leaderboard runs, and whether Qwen's actual open weights (graded here on 17 August) reset the 30B class again. Until then, the honest label on both is "promising, unverified."

SOURCES 1 Muse Glimmer VRAM/throughput — 4-bit K-quant ~16.8GB, vision projector 1.4GB, DFlash speculative decoding 74.9 → 233.4 tok/s on RTX 5090 (3.1×); vendor benchmarks unverified — Unsloth docs; NVIDIA Technical Blog; bartowski/Muse-Glimmer-30B-GGUF. 2 Nemotron 3.5 Lightning home-lab fit — 4-bit GGUF ~25GB (fits 32GB 5090), NVFP4 needs TensorRT-LLM/vLLM, GGUF-via-Ollama the practical single-card path; dual-5090 (64GB) for long-context/BF16 headroom — NVIDIA "Local AI" blog; DataCamp. 3 TSMC, 9–10 Aug 2026 — July revenue US\$14.5bn (+45% y/y), FY revenue-growth guidance raised above 40%, 2026 capex US\$60–64bn; chairman C.C. Wei "AI demand extremely robust" — CNBC (10 Aug); Yahoo Finance. 4 Qwen3.8-27B / Qwen3.8-Max open weights unshipped as of ~12 Aug (window through ~16 Aug), no licence named; community FP8 repo is unofficial — QwenLM; digitalapplied; neomanex (grade 17 Aug). 5 Muse Glimmer benchmarks vendor-published, no independent eval; preparedness self-rated without red-team detail — MarkTechPost; model card.

THE KIT · MADE BY GOOGLE

A Foldable Goes Two-Nanometre — and the Hinge Asks the Buy-Once Question

Google's 12 August event led with the Pixel 11 Pro Fold at US\$1,899: a Tensor G6 on TSMC's 2nm process, an eight-inch inner display, and a seven-year software promise. It is the longest-supported foldable of the cycle — and the one component you can't spec your way past is the fold itself.

The pitch is durability of a specific kind. At its 12 August Made by Google event, Google announced the Pixel 11 Pro Fold at US\$1,899 (roughly S\$2,450, local pricing unconfirmed): a Tensor G6 built on TSMC's 2nm node, an eight-inch inner OLED at 3,000 nits, a 10.1mm folded profile at 239 grams, 16GB of RAM across all tiers, and — the number that matters for a buy-once buyer — seven years of software support.¹ It ships around October, after the rest of the Pixel 11 line. For a reader whose instinct is to buy the quality version and keep it, the Fold makes the strongest case of the cycle: the most efficient chip, the most memory, the longest support runway. And yet the one variable no spec sheet resolves is mechanical — a folding display carries hinge and crease wear that a slab flagship simply does not, so "buy once" is the philosophy being tested here, not merely satisfied.¹

Two companions rounded out the event. The Pixel Watch 5, announced the same day, ships 20 August at US\$399 (about S\$515): a Snapdragon W5 Gen 2, more RAM, better dual-band GPS and Wear OS 7, with

battery essentially flat on last year's — an incremental year, honestly framed even by its boosters as "a US\$50 bet that AI beats speed."² And Sony's 1000X "The Collexion," the 10th-anniversary flagship over-ear, finally reached shelves around 7 August at US\$649.99: mastering-house tuning, a metal band, 12-mic ANC — a materials-and-prestige upgrade over the standard XM6 rather than a functional leap, which is why one outlet called it "the anniversary headphones most people won't buy."³

7 yrs

SOFTWARE SUPPORT ON THE PIXEL 11 PRO FOLD — THE LONGEST OF ANY FOLDABLE THIS CYCLE, AND THE STRONGEST BUY-ONCE ARGUMENT. THE COUNTER-ARGUMENT IS THE HINGE, WHICH NO UPDATE PATCHES.¹

STILL ON THE SHELF

Pixel Watch 5 — ships 20 Aug, US\$399. Snapdragon W5 Gen 2, Wear OS 7; battery flat. A Stephen Curry edition follows 3 Sep at US\$579.²

Sony 1000X "The Collexion" — now buyable, US\$649.99. Announced May, on shelves ~7 Aug; anniversary materials over the XM6, not a new ANC ceiling.³

THE CHATTER — "WATCH, DON'T BUY YET"

Pre-launch coverage flagged the non-Fold Pixel 11 as only a minor refresh on the Tensor G6, and the community's line on the Fold is measured: the headline 100× zoom is AI-enhanced rather than optical, and an October ship date makes it a "watch, don't buy yet" for a reader who waits for the durability reports before committing to a hinge.¹ The Sony's reception is warmer on materials than on value — the mastering-house tuning is real, the case for it over the cheaper XM6 is aesthetic.³

THE SCEPTIC — THE DURABILITY TAX ON "BUY ONCE"

A foldable inverts the buy-once logic it seems to satisfy. The longer you intend to keep a device, the more a moving mechanical joint matters — and hinges and creases are exactly what fail on a keep-it-forever timeline that a monolithic phone survives untouched.¹ The falsifier is boring and dated: the first wave of long-term hinge-durability and crease reports after the October ship. Until those land, the honest verdict for a buy-once reader is the community's — watch, don't buy. (The Insta360 X6 stays parked here too: its measured lab review is not expected until roughly 26 August.)⁴

SOURCES 1 Google Pixel 11 Pro Fold — announced Made by Google, 12 Aug 2026; US\$1,899, Tensor G6 (TSMC 2nm), 8-inch inner OLED 3,000 nits, 10.1mm/239g, 16GB RAM, 7-yr support, ships ~Oct; 100× zoom AI-enhanced not optical — Droid-Life (12 Aug); Android Central; Engadget. Genuine product image: representative (see attestation). 2 Pixel Watch 5 — 12 Aug, ships 20 Aug, US\$399, Snapdragon W5 Gen 2, Wear OS 7, battery flat; Curry edition US\$579 (3 Sep) — Droid-Life; Memeburn. 3 Sony 1000X "The Collexion" — on shelves ~7 Aug, US\$649.99, 10th-anniversary flagship, 12-mic ANC, mastering-house tuning; PhoneArena "headphones most people won't buy" — Sony press; New Atlas; PhoneArena. 4 Insta360 X6 — measured lab review expected ~26 Aug; parked until then (No. 70) — this desk.

THE GOOD LIFE · A WATCH WITH A LIVERY

A Square German Chronograph for the Price of a Good Watch, Not a Grail

Union Glashütte's Averin Chronograph "Sachsen Classic 2026" is a 41mm racing-liveried square in steel at €3,700, limited to 350 pieces and timed to a vintage-car rally. It is a genuinely well-made value-luxury object — and the livery, not the movement, is what you're paying for. That's the appeal, and the tell.

Sometimes the object is honest about what it is. Union Glashütte — the Saxon house under the Swatch Group, sister to Glashütte Original — released the Averin Chronograph "Sachsen Classic 2026" this fortnight, timed to the vintage-car rally of the same name (14–15 August): a 41-by-41mm stainless-steel square, dashboard-inspired dial in white with signal-red and greyscale racing stripes, on the calibre UNG-27.S2, an automatic chronograph on a Valjoux 7750 base fitted with a silicon balance spring and a 65-hour reserve, at €3,700 for 350 numbered pieces, with two straps in the box.¹ For a buy-once reader, the maths is clean: a real German-finished chronograph with a silicon hairspring, under about S\$5,500, tied to a dated event. It is not a grail and does not pretend to be — the quality entry point, priced like one.

The tell is in what commands the money. The livery — the 1970s-and-80s motorsport palette, the square case that nods to a Monaco, the 350-piece number — is the value on offer; the movement is a well-dressed workhorse, not horological scarcity.¹ That is a perfectly good bargain if you want the look and the

story, and a poor one if you expect it to hold value like an independent's in-house calibre.² Elsewhere on the desk, two objects sit in the "noted, not now" column: Sennheiser's Momentum True Wireless 5 earbuds are leaked for a 19 August launch near €300 (a leak, and below the buy-once bar), and Hyatt's new "Atona" luxury-ryokan brand is opening its first Japanese houses — Hakone, Yufu, Yakushima — through 2026 at roughly US\$800–1,300 a night, a brand launch worth tracking for a later trip.³

€3,700

THE AVERIN CHRONOGRAPH, 350 PIECES — A SILICON-HAIRSPRING GERMAN CHRONO AT THE PRICE OF A GOOD WATCH. WHAT YOU BUY IS THE LIVERY AND THE FINISH; THE BASE MOVEMENT IS A WORKHORSE. NOT INVESTMENT ADVICE.¹

ON THE SHELF

Sennheiser Momentum True Wireless 5 — leaked 19 Aug, ~€300. Five colours. A leak, single-sourced, and under the buy-once threshold; noted, not led.³

Hyatt "Atona" ryokan brand — first houses through 2026. Hakone, Yufu, Yakushima; ~US\$800–1,300/night; points-eligible. A brand launch, not a single dated opening.³

THE CHATTER — THE SQUARE-RACING-CHRONO LANE IS CROWDED

On the watch forums the Averin drew genuine interest as a value proposition — an active WatchForum intro thread, a "first look" and an "introducing" from Monochrome within days.¹ The recurring caveat from collectors: the square-racing-chronograph lane is crowded, and a TAG Monaco casts a long shadow over any homage to it. The appeal is the price-to-finish ratio; the reservation is that you are buying into a well-trodden design idea, not an original one.²

THE SCEPTIC — THIN RESALE IS THE PRICE OF THE STORY

Enjoy it, but not as a store of value. Limited editions from a second-tier Swatch-Group house have thin, soft secondary markets; the 350-piece number is a marketing scarcity, not a horological one, and a 7750 base — however nicely finished — does not underwrite resale the way an independent's in-house calibre can.² The falsifier for the "great value" read is simple: whether these trade near retail or well below it at twelve months. Buy it to wear, not to flip. This is context for a collector, not investment advice.

SOURCES 1 Union Glashütte Averin Chronograph LE "Sachsen Classic 2026," ref. D015.527.17.011.09 — 41×41mm steel, calibre UNG-27.S2 (Valjoux 7750 base, silicon balance spring, ~65h), €3,700, 350 pieces, two straps, timed to the Sachsen Classic rally (14–15 Aug) — Monochrome (Introducing); Gear Patrol; The Manual; union-glashuette.com. Genuine product image: representative (see attestation). 2 Collector caveat — crowded square-racing-chrono segment, thin resale for second-tier LEs — WatchForum.com; Monochrome. Not investment advice. 3 Sennheiser Momentum True Wireless 5 leak (~19 Aug, ~€300, single-sourced); Hyatt "Atona" luxury-ryokan brand — Hakone/Yufu/Yakushima through 2026, ~US\$800–1,300/night — gagadget; Japan Times; Unseen Japan.

SCREEN & SOUND · THE ROOM AND THE REVIEWS

Two Comedies for Grown-Ups Died on the Same Weekend

A Will Gluck rom-com and a Broken Lizard sequel both opened soft, reviving the "theatrical comedy is dead" verdict — even as one of them posted an audience score well above its critics'. Meanwhile the acclaim for Phoebe Bridgers runs ahead of a single fan who's heard the record. Two gaps between the number and the room.

The fresh signal at the box office was an absence. On the 7–9 August weekend, *One Night Only* — Will Gluck's R-rated New York rom-com with Monica Barbaro and Callum Turner, from the team behind the sleeper hit *Anyone but You* — opened third at about US\$5.5 million, against a Broken Lizard sequel, *Super Troopers 3*, at roughly US\$4 million (its predecessor opened at \$15.2 million in 2018).¹ The reflex read is "comedy can't open." But the more interesting number is the split: *One Night Only* carried a 72% audience score against critics near 47% — audiences warmer than the reviews, the inverse of the week's other culture story.¹ Gluck's films historically open soft and leg out, so the honest verdict is to watch the hold, not the debut.²

The inverse gap is Phoebe Bridgers. Her third solo album, *Lost Weekend* (Dead Oceans), arrives 14 August under a wall of critical acclaim — a Metacritic in the low 90s, an AlbumOfTheYear critic score around 94, a guest list from Antonoff to Julien Baker to Bo Burnham — before a single listener has lived with it.³ That is the tell this desk keeps returning to:

the critics have glazed, and the room hasn't voted. On the fan boards the pushback is already audible — "not even the critics have glazed this hard."³ The 14 August New Music Friday also brings Ayra Starr's *STARRGIRL* (features from Wizkid and Rema) and Becky G's *Baraja Bendita*; and looking ahead, the 83rd Venice Film Festival (2–12 September) has set a board that includes Kore-eda's live-action *Look Back* — a manga adaptation worth the flight-planner's attention.⁴

Two gaps in one week: audiences warmer than the critics on a comedy, critics warmer than any fan on an album.

NEW MUSIC FRIDAY — 14 AUG

Phoebe Bridgers — *Lost Weekend*. Critic acclaim in the low 90s; the user-vs-critic settle is what to watch. Grade the gap ~28 Aug.³

Ayra Starr — *STARRGIRL*. 16 tracks; features Wizkid ("Gimme Dat") and Rema. Plus Becky G's *Baraja Bendita*.⁴

THE CHATTER — R/MOVIES AND R/POPHEADS ON THE TWO SPLITS

On r/movies the double flop reads as another data point in the "comedies can't open theatrically" argument, with the countervailing note that Gluck's brand of rom-com is exactly the kind that legs out on word of mouth.² On the music side, the fan boards frame the Bridgers scores as a critic-consensus phenomenon awaiting a listener verdict — excitement tempered by score-skepticism, no user aggregate settled at release-eve.³ Same lesson, two desks: the published number and the lived reaction are not the same measurement.

THE SCEPTIC — ONE WEEKEND IS NOT A GENRE'S OBITUARY

Resist the tidy "comedy is dead" headline. Two soft openings on one weekend is a sample of two, not a trend; Gluck movies specifically underperform on opening night and recover over weeks, so the debut is the least reliable number to eulogise a genre with.² The falsifier is dated: *One Night Only*'s second-weekend hold, and whether that 72% audience score converts into legs. On Bridgers, the falsifier is the user aggregate at ~28 August — does the room agree with the room-service reviews, or not? Grade both, don't pre-write them.³

SOURCES 1 Box office, 7–9 Aug 2026 — *One Night Only* (dir. Will Gluck; Monica Barbaro, Callum Turner) opened #3 ~US\$5.5m, RT ~47% critics / 72% audience, Metacritic 40, B+ CinemaScore; *Super Troopers 3* (Broken Lizard) ~US\$4.0m (vs ST2's \$15.2m in 2018) — Slashfilm; Forbes (7 Aug); The-Numbers. Figures directional; verify against Box Office Mojo. 2 Gluck films historically leg out on word of mouth — r/movies; trade commentary; characterised. 3 Phoebe Bridgers, *Lost Weekend* (Dead Oceans, 14 Aug 2026) — Metacritic low-90s "universal acclaim," AOTY critic ~94; guests incl. Antonoff, Julien Baker, Lucy Dacus, Bo Burnham; fan-board pushback "not even the critics have glazed this hard" — NME; Rolling Stone; AOTY. 4 Ayra Starr, *STARRGIRL* (ft. Wizkid, Rema); Becky G, *Baraja Bendita* (14 Aug); Venice Film Festival 83rd (2–12 Sep) incl. Kore-eda's live-action *Look Back* — BellaNaija; Variety; Deadline.

THE FAMILY DESK · THE LEVER THAT ACTUALLY MOVES

Parents Fixate on Screens. The Research Points at Sleep.

A new analysis of more than 6,000 children aged 10 to 13 finds that of four lifestyle levers — sleep, screen time, activity, diet — sleep is by far the strongest link between a child's mental-health symptoms and how they actually do at school and with friends. The thing parents watch is not the thing that moves. General guidance, not medical advice.

The finding is a quiet correction to a decade of screen panic. Analysing the large Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development cohort — more than 6,000 children for academic outcomes, over 7,000 for social problems, all aged 10 to 13 — researchers at UC Davis Health asked which of four levers (sleep, screen time, physical activity, diet) best explains the link between a child's mental-health symptoms and real-world outcomes.¹ Sleep won, and not narrowly: it accounted for about 18.5% of the association between depression symptoms and lower grades, 36.3% for anxiety, and 8.3% for psychotic-like experiences — with the effect strongest in children already carrying symptoms. Screen time, the lever parents fixate on, was a comparatively minor mediator.¹ The lead author's own word was "surprised." For an optimisation-minded family, the message is almost anticlimactic: protect the nine-to-eleven hours an eleven-year-old needs, and you are pulling the single most load-bearing lever for both mood and school.

The practical translation is the one this reader already runs on herself. The mechanism is displacement — late-night screens push sleep out, and it is the lost sleep, more than the screen, that shows up in the morning's mood and the term's grades.² So the intervention is behavioural and familiar: a consistent bedtime and no device in the bedroom after lights-out, the same sleep hygiene an Oura or Whoop household already runs on itself, applied to an eleven-year-old. The study is observational and cannot prove causation — it demotes screens as a *mediator*, not as a thing worth managing — but it reorders the priority list: fix the sleep first. General guidance, not medical advice.

36%

SHARE OF THE LINK BETWEEN ANXIETY SYMPTOMS AND LOWER GRADES THAT SLEEP ACCOUNTS FOR IN 10-TO-13-YEAR-OLDS — THE STRONGEST SINGLE MEDIATOR THE STUDY FOUND. SCREEN TIME WAS MINOR BY COMPARISON.¹

ABCD COHORT · N>6,000

SLEEP > SCREENS

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — SLEEP IS HAVING A MOMENT

The finding lands into a broader 2026 discourse in which "sleep outranks diet and exercise as a longevity lever" has circulated all year; this study gives the parenting version a hard number. The overlap with the Fitness desk is not a coincidence — the same lever the reader tracks on her own wrist is the one to protect in her daughter ([p18](#)).³

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T OVER-READ ONE OBSERVATIONAL STUDY

The disciplined caveats are the study's own. It is cross-sectional and observational — it maps mediation, not causation — and "sleep matters most" among four levers does not mean the other three don't matter.¹ The field's leading anti-alarmists, UC Irvine's Candice Odgers and Oxford's Andrew Przybylski, have long argued the screen-harm story is oversold; Przybylski's line that the screen-time/well-being correlation can be "a rounding error" is the useful counterweight here.⁴ The point is not that screens are harmless — it is that the causal arrow may run through the sleep they displace, so the fix is a bedtime, not a panic. What would change the read: a longitudinal follow-up that isolates sleep as the driver.

SOURCES 1 Smucny et al., "Mediating effects of healthy lifestyle factors on associations between mental health and functional outcomes in early adolescence," *Psychological Medicine* (2026) — ABCD cohort, ages 10–13, n>6,000 (academic)/7,000 (social); sleep mediates 18.5% (depression → grades), 36.3% (anxiety), 8.3% (psychotic-like exp.); coverage early Aug 2026 — UC Davis Health newsroom; news-medical.net (4 Aug); MedicalXpress. 2 Mechanism = displacement of sleep by late-night screens; behavioural fix (consistent bedtime, no bedroom device) — study discussion; UC Davis. General guidance, not medical advice. 3 "Sleep as a longevity lever" — 2026 health round-ups (SUCCESS; Yahoo Health); discourse, single-sourced — flagged. 4 Candice Odgers (UC Irvine), Andrew Przybylski (Oxford) — screen-harm skepticism; Przybylski "rounding error" characterisation — Nature commentary; interviews.

THE TWEEN YEARS • WHAT THE INSTRUMENT MISSES

At Eleven, "She Seems Fine" Is a Weak Reading

Two 2026 studies converge on a quiet finding: pre-teen girls report more anxiety than their parents can see, and the gap widens as puberty advances. The parental instrument under-reads exactly when the signal is rising. General guidance, not medical advice.

If the sleep study reorders the levers, this one recalibrates the gauge. A Florida International University team found that children aged 10 to 13 consistently rate their own anxiety higher than their parents rate it for them — and the gap grows as puberty advances, widest for children already carrying a diagnosis.¹ A University of Georgia study points to a mechanism: rising testosterone (and early DHEA, from around age nine) was the strongest hormonal predictor of anxiety and depression symptoms in girls aged 10 to 12, above estradiol.² Read together, and read carefully — both are correlational, and the Georgia sample size wasn't obtainable from the summaries — they land a practical point for a parent of an eleven-year-old: "she seems fine" is a low-resolution instrument at exactly the age the internal signal is climbing. The fix is not surveillance; it is asking directly, and periodically, rather than inferring from the surface.¹

The policy weather shifted too. On 5 August the US Senate Commerce Committee advanced five bipartisan kids-online-safety bills, three of them aimed at AI chatbots — mandating crisis-referral

behaviour and parental-notification features.³ It is a live thread rather than law, and worth one correction for the record: the widely-shared "romantic chatbot" scandal that colours these debates dates to August 2025, not this year — don't let a year-old story masquerade as fresh evidence.³ The through-line across both Family pages is the issue's spine in miniature: the visible metric (screens, a calm surface, a viral headline) is not the load-bearing one (sleep, a rising internal signal, the actual bill text). General guidance, not medical advice.

10–13

THE AGE BAND WHERE CHILDREN'S SELF-RATED ANXIETY RUNS CONSISTENTLY ABOVE THEIR PARENTS' ESTIMATE — AND THE GAP WIDENS THROUGH PUBERTY. THE PARENTAL READ UNDER-REPORTS EXACTLY WHEN IT MATTERS.¹

"She seems fine" is a low-resolution instrument at exactly the age the internal signal is climbing.

THE CHATTER — PARENTS ON THE "INVISIBLE" YEARS

In the parenting communities the FIU finding rang true to lived experience — the sense that the calm eleven-year-old at the dinner table is not always the same child inside, and that the honest tool is a direct, low-drama check-in rather than a monitoring app.¹ The counsel that travels well: normalise the question, keep it routine, and don't outsource the read to a device that measures screen minutes but not the mood underneath them.

THE SCEPTIC — HORMONES AREN'T DESTINY, AND CORRELATION ISN'T A DIAGNOSIS

Two guardrails. First, the hormonal link is correlational; "testosterone predicts symptoms" is a population signal, not a prophecy for any individual child, and reading it as one is its own kind of alarmism.² Second, a parent-child reporting gap is expected in early adolescence and does not by itself indicate a disorder — the useful response is attention, not escalation.¹ The falsifier for over-reading either study is a longitudinal design that fails to reproduce the effect, or that shows the gap closing with ordinary developmental time. Watch, ask, and keep the instrument honest. Not medical advice.

SOURCES ¹ FIU (Amanda Baker et al.), *Research on Child and Adolescent Psychopathology* (2026) — children 10–13 self-rate anxiety above parents' ratings; gap widens with puberty, worst with a diagnosis — [news.fiu.edu](#); MedicalXpress. ² University of Georgia, *Psychoneuroendocrinology* (coverage Jul 2026) — testosterone (and early DHEA) strongest hormonal predictor of anxiety/depression in girls 10–12, above estradiol; sample size not obtainable from summaries — [fcs.uga.edu](#); MedicalXpress. ³ US Senate Commerce Committee advanced 5 bipartisan kids-online-safety bills, 5 Aug 2026 (3 target AI chatbots — crisis-referral, parental notification); the "romantic chatbot" scandal dates to Aug 2025, not 2026 — [commerce.senate.gov](#). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK · THE SCARE THAT DIDN'T ARRIVE

The Market Braced for a Hot Print. It Got a Mild One — and Gold Rose Anyway.

July US inflation came in at 3.4%, in line and cooler than June; the odds of a September rate hike fell, and ten-year yields eased. Yet gold pushed toward US\$4,500 and bitcoin went nowhere. The same benign data priced three assets in three directions — which is the whole lesson.

US CPI (YOY)	CORE CPI	US 10Y	GOLD	BITCOIN
3.4%	2.5%	~4.65%	~\$4,420	~\$64.2k

Last issue this desk described an oil-led inflation scare: Brent near US\$88 had pushed ten-year yields to a one-month high and bid up gold, all before the data could speak. On 12 August the data spoke, and it was mild. July headline CPI rose 0.1% on the month and 3.4% on the year — down from 3.5% in June and in line with consensus — with core at 0.2% and 2.5%, shelter contributing about two-thirds of the monthly rise.¹ This cycle the Fed's live debate is hike-versus-hold, not cut; a benign print did not open the door to easing, it simply lowered the odds of a September hike, which futures now put at roughly two-in-five against a majority for a hold, ahead of the 15–16 September meeting.² Ten-year yields eased back toward 4.65%, equities firmed modestly, and the dollar held near 100 — the tidy, textbook reaction to inflation that behaved.

The instructive part is what didn't follow the textbook. Gold, rather than fading on a cooler print and a firmer dollar, pushed toward US\$4,500 —

because with real yields still positive (a 4.65% ten-year against 3.4% inflation) and no rate cut in sight, gold's bid is not an inflation trade at all; it is haven demand, priced by fear and geopolitics, climbing despite higher-for-longer.³ Bitcoin, the liquidity-sensitive asset, did the opposite of nothing dramatic: it sat where it has sat for five weeks, roughly US\$62,000–66,000, because an in-line print delivered no new easing impulse — no fresh liquidity to fuel a breakout in either direction.³ One benign number, three prices, three drivers: real yields for gold, liquidity for bitcoin, and rate-path relief for equities. This is market explanation, not advice; forecasts are flagged as forecasts.

3.4%

JULY US HEADLINE CPI, DOWN FROM 3.5% AND IN LINE — THE "SCARE" THAT DIDN'T MATERIALISE. YIELDS EASED; GOLD ROSE ANYWAY, ON HAVEN DEMAND RATHER THAN INFLATION. THE NUMBER AND THE DRIVER CAME APART.¹

HIGHER-FOR-LONGER

DOLLAR BID

HIKE ODDS FALL

THE CHATTER — WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

The read across the four anchors is a soft-landing-adjacent regime with a hawkish tail. A benign CPI is mildly supportive for global equities (VWRA near its 52-week high) and steadies global bonds as the hike scare recedes; the equity–bond correlation is behaving, so diversification is helping at the margin rather than hurting.³ Gold's strength is a fear premium, not an inflation hedge working — useful to read for what it signals about risk demand. Bitcoin is range-bound precisely because the liquidity catalyst it needs didn't arrive. The regime call: higher-for-longer, dollar-bid, no easing yet.²

THE SCEPTIC — ONE SOFT PRINT IS NOT A TREND, AND BOJ IS THE WILDCARD

Don't extrapolate a single in-line month into "inflation is beaten." The Fed still faces inflation well above target with no cut priced, so the relief is that a hike looks less likely — not that policy eases.² The live wildcard is the Bank of Japan: having hiked to 1.0% in June and held in July with a hawkish summary of opinions, a firmer yen path from Tokyo could unsettle the dollar-carry trades that anchor this calm, with USD/JPY near 159 keeping intervention chatter alive.⁴ The falsifier for the "benign" read is the next CPI running hot, or a BoJ move that reprises the dollar. This is education, not a buy or sell call.

SOURCES 1 US BLS, CPI July 2026 (released 12 Aug 2026) — headline +0.1% m/m / +3.4% y/y (from 3.5%), core +0.2% / +2.5% (from 2.6%), shelter ~2/3 of the monthly rise, in line with consensus — CNBC; Kiplinger; Forbes. 2 Fed funds 3.50–3.75%; post-CPI CME FedWatch ~42% Sept hike / ~62% hold (indicative), FOMC 15–16 Sep 2026 — CNBC; CME FedWatch. 3 Levels ~12 Aug — 10Y ~4.65%, DXY ~99.8, gold ~\$4,420 (toward \$4,500), BTC ~\$64.2k (range \$62–66k ~5 wks), VWRA ~\$194 near 52-wk high; gold = haven/real-yields, BTC = liquidity — FXstreet; Yahoo Finance; Fortune. 4 BoJ hiked to 1.0% Jun 2026, held Jul with hawkish "summary of opinions"; USD/JPY ~159 — BoJ; wires. Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

THE RABBIT HOLE • THE INVITATION

The Band Everyone Left, and the Hobby That Wouldn't Die With It

Shortwave listening should be dead. The great international broadcasters have fled the band for a decade — the BBC to North America, Radio Australia entirely, the Voice of America's transmitters going dark last year. And yet the hobby is cheaper and, by some measures, larger than ever, because the price of entry collapsed from a US\$200 receiver to a US\$30 USB stick. This is a descent into a band of static, and the people who still tune it.

Turn the dial and the first thing you hear is noise — and then, buried in it, a voice from the other side of the planet. Shortwave listening, or SWL, is the hobby of receiving broadcasts on the high-frequency band, roughly 1.7 to 30 megahertz, and its founding fact is that receiving needs no licence anywhere; a licence is only ever for transmitting.¹ That is the on-ramp: zero gatekeeping. The gateway moment the community keeps describing is the first distant catch — a broadcaster in a language from a continent away — or the first accidental brush with a numbers station, a robotic voice reading five-figure groups into the void.¹ The other gateway, the modern one, is the realisation that you can do all of it with a roughly US\$30 RTL-SDR USB dongle and a laptop, watching a whole slice of spectrum scroll past as a "waterfall" rather than tuning a knob blind.²

The paradox is the whole story. The broadcasters really have left: the BBC World Service ended shortwave to North America and the Pacific in 2001 and cut radio in some ten languages in 2023; Radio Australia switched off its shortwave entirely on 31 January 2017 (China moved onto the vacated

frequencies within weeks); and in 2025 the Voice of America and its sister networks were gutted, the Edward R. Murrow transmitting station shut down that March.³ And yet the installed base is still estimated at around 600 million sets worldwide, and three forces are quietly reviving the listening hobby even as broadcasting dies: the collapse in entry price, a surge of prepper and grid-down interest in a receiver that needs no internet or cell tower, and — for the technically minded — an endless supply of new things to *decode*.² The band is thinner. What you can do on it is not.

~600M

SHORTWAVE SETS ESTIMATED WORLDWIDE — NICHE IN NORTH AMERICA, MAINSTREAM ACROSS MUCH OF THE GLOBAL SOUTH. THE RECEIVERS DIDN'T VANISH; THE BROADCASTERS DID, AND THE HOBBY MIGRATED TO LISTENING AND DECODING.²

Turn the dial and the first thing you hear is noise — and then, buried in it, a voice from the other side of the planet.

THE RETREAT — WHO LEFT THE BAND, AND WHEN

BBC World Service. Ended shortwave to North America and the Pacific in 2001; cut radio output in ~10 languages in 2023.³

Radio Australia. Switched off all shortwave on 31 Jan 2017, calling it "out of date"; China took the frequencies.³

Voice of America / USAGM. Mass-suspended in 2025; the Murrow transmitting station shut down 16 Mar 2025.³

THE CHATTER — THREE TRIBES, ONE BAND

The hobby is really three overlapping tribes, and they don't always get along. The DXers chase weak, distant signals and mail off "reception reports" for a confirmation card; the SDR crowd came for the technology — waterfalls, decoders, laptops — and skews younger; and a large, growing preppers-and-self-reliance contingent pitches shortwave as news that survives when the grid doesn't.² What follows is the map they share: where they gather, what is genuinely left to hear, the gear worth buying once, and the argument the hobby keeps having with itself.

SOURCES ¹ Shortwave listening — receiving the HF band (~1.7–30 MHz); no licence required to receive, only to transmit; "gateway" catches (distant broadcasters, numbers stations) — Wikipedia, "Shortwave listening"; NBC News, "Shortwave radio still packs an audible thrill." ² ~600M sets worldwide; the SDR revolution (~US\$30 RTL-SDR dongle + waterfall); three revival drivers (price, prepping, decoding); the three tribes — Wikipedia; rtl-sdr.com; offgridweb.com; survivalistprepper.net. ³ Broadcaster retreat — BBC WS shortwave to N. America/Pacific ended 2001, ~10 languages cut 2023; Radio Australia off shortwave 31 Jan 2017; VOA/USAGM 2025 mass-suspension, Murrow station shut 16 Mar 2025 — Radio World; Al Jazeera (27 Jan 2023); SWLing Post; Axios (Mar 2025).

THE DEEP END · THE MAP AND THE SIGNAL

Where They Gather, and What's Actually Left to Hear

The hub is a blog. The SWLing Post, run by Thomas Witherspoon (callsign K4SWL) from North Carolina, is the movement's centre of gravity — reviews, news, pirate and numbers-station lore — and Witherspoon himself, interviewed by the BBC and profiled in the *Wall Street Journal*, is the hobby's most-quoted advocate, his ad-free YouTube channel built on "real-time, real-life, no-edit" field recordings.¹ Around it orbit the subreddits: r/amateurradio, the big tent at about 216,000 members with heavy SWL crossover; r/RTLSDR, the technical and SDR heart; and r/shortwave, the broadcast-listening community that trades "what did you hear last night" logs.¹ Deeper down sits HFUnderground, the message board for pirates, utility signals and spy stations, with its own inside-joke culture and its classic pirate calling frequency of 6925 kilohertz.²

The most magnetic material is the numbers stations — robotic voices reading coded groups, still broadcasting in 2026. UVB-76, "The Buzzer," transmits a monotonous drone on 4625 kHz, occasionally broken by spoken Russian codewords; on 24 June 2026 it sent some twenty coded voice

messages in a single day, and the serious monitors at Priyom.org tie it to a Russian military command network.³ The legends are mostly dead now: Britain's "Lincolnshire Poacher," direction-found to a Cyprus air base, went silent in July 2008; Cuba's digital HM01 has been off-air since its transmitter failed in August 2024. Their eerie afterlife is *The Conet Project*, the 1997 recordings that seeded numbers stations into indie music and album art.³ And the sharpest schism in the hobby is over WebSDR and KiwiSDR — internet receivers you tune through a browser from anywhere. The SWLing Post calls them a way to "escape the noise"; the purists on forums ask whether hearing a signal through someone else's antenna over the internet is even the hobby at all.⁴

4625 kHz

UVB-76, "THE BUZZER" — A COLD WAR DRONE STILL ON THE AIR IN 2026, TIED TO A RUSSIAN MILITARY NETWORK. ON 24 JUNE IT BROKE INTO SOME TWENTY CODED VOICE MESSAGES IN A DAY. NOBODY OUTSIDE MOSCOW KNOWS WHY.³

SWLING POST · K4SWL

PRİYOM.ORG

6925 KHZ · PIRATES

STILL ON THE BANDS — THE HONEST INVENTORY (2026)

Broadcasters. Radio Romania International (widely called the best English news still reliably on shortwave), WRMI Florida, China Radio International, Radio Habana Cuba — and, increasingly, US religious giants

(WWCR, EWTN/WEWN, Adventist World Radio).⁵

Time & weather. WWV/WWVH atomic time signals on 2.5/5/10/15/20 MHz, still 24/7 after 100 years; WEFAX weather-fax charts anyone can decode with a soundcard and free software.⁵

Data & voice. HFDL aircraft data over the oceans (decode it, feed Airframes.io); FT8, now the most active HF mode, reading signals at -21 dB — inaudible to the ear, legible to software; ham SSB; pirates on 43m.⁵

THE GEAR, PART ONE — THE TWO PATHS IN

Shortwave splits into two ways in. **Path A, the SDR:** a dongle or box feeding a computer, where the radio is software and you see the whole band at once. The learn-the-ropes entry is the RTL-SDR Blog V4 (about US\$40 with a dipole kit); the real first "serious" receiver most of the community points to is the Airspy HF+ Discovery at US\$169 — the DXer's darling, with a front end reviewers call "stratospheric" for the money.⁶ Above it sit the SDRplay RSPdx-R2 (~US\$235) for wideband coverage and, for the obsessive, the RX-888 MkII (~US\$170), which records up to 64 MHz of spectrum at once — a capability that used to cost US\$1,500.⁶ **Path B, the classic radio:** a self-contained portable you just switch on. The consensus best-value 2026 pick is the Tecsun PL-330 (~US\$90, real single-sideband); the cult flagship is the Tecsun PL-990x (~US\$300); and the endgame tabletop is the Icom IC-R8600 at about US\$2,750.⁷

SOURCES 1 SWLing Post / Thomas Witherspoon (K4SWL) — the hub blog, ad-free field-recording YouTube; r/amateurradio ~216,000 members (RedditList, 2026), r/RTLSDR and r/shortwave (exact counts not independently verified this session — flagged) — swling.com; RedditList. 2 HFUnderground — pirate/utility/numbers board; 6925 kHz pirate calling frequency — hfunderground.com wiki. 3 UVB-76 "The Buzzer," 4625 kHz, ~20 coded voice messages on 24 Jun 2026, tied to a Russian military network per Priyom; Lincolnshire Poacher silent Jul 2008; Cuban HM01 off-air since Aug 2024; *The Conet Project* (1997) — Priyom.org; hfunderground.com wiki; Wikipedia. 4 WebSDR/KiwiSDR "is it still the hobby?" debate — SWLing Post (pro); Transmission / RadioReference forums (purist); quotes via search summaries — flagged. 5 What's left in 2026 — Radio Romania International, WRMI, CRI, Radio Habana; US religious broadcasters (WWCR/EWTN/AWR); WWV/WWVH (2.5–20 MHz); WEFAX; HFDL (Airframes.io); FT8 (~21 dB, most active HF mode); pirates — radio-hobbyist.com; NIST; sigidwiki; Radio World. 6 SDR tier — RTL-SDR Blog V4 ~US\$40; Airspy HF+ Discovery US\$169; SDRplay RSPdx-R2 ~US\$235; RX-888 MkII ~US\$170 (64 MHz capture) — rtl-sdr.com; airspy.com; SDRplay; community verdicts (r/RTLSDR). 7 Portable tier — Tecsun PL-330 ~US\$90, PL-990x ~US\$300; Icom IC-R8600 ~US\$2,749.95 — Anon-Co; GigaParts; SWLing Post.

THE DEEP END · THE ANTENNA, THE NOISE, AND THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

The Real Game Isn't the Radio — It's the Signal-to-Noise

Here is the line the whole hobby repeats, and the one that makes it the issue's spine made literal: the antenna is the most important part of your radio equation, and in a city what matters is not raw signal but signal-to-noise.¹ Indoors you drown in man-made electrical noise — chargers, LED bulbs, powerline networking — so the money goes not on the receiver but on rejecting the hum. A balanced magnetic loop does that: the Airspy YouLoop at about US\$35 is the "cheap magic" (passive, wanting a sensitive SDR behind it), the active MLA-30+ runs US\$30–37, and the high end (Bonito, W6LVP) filled the gap when Wellbrook, the old gold standard, closed in 2023.¹ The buy-once inflection here is not a four-figure receiver but the roughly US\$600 tier — an Airspy HF+ Discovery and a good loop, which out-listens every portable and most vintage grails on weak-signal HF.²

The cutting edge, honestly, is software and price, not a revolutionary radio. The RTL-SDR dongle went end-of-line and was replaced by a "Lite" V4L in May 2026; the genuinely disruptive move is the RX-888 MkII bringing 64-megahertz wideband capture under US\$200, and SDRplay's cross-platform SDRconnect

app maturing with a decoder API.³ Anyone holding out for a revolutionary new receiver should just buy the Airspy now. And the Singapore angle sharpens the whole argument: receive-only listening needs no IMDA licence (the framework licenses transmitting, not listening — verify before you rely on it), the local amateur exam is suspended, so hams take the FCC route via SARTS, and a dense HDB block, with residents documenting radio interference between floors, is close to a worst-case noise environment — which is exactly why the loop antenna and the remote KiwiSDR matter more here.⁴

~US\$244

THE "SERIOUS FROM DAY ONE" STARTER KIT: AN RTL-SDR V4 TO LEARN THE SOFTWARE (~US\$40), AN AIRSPY HF+ DISCOVERY TO ACTUALLY HEAR (US\$169), A YOULOOP TO BEAT THE NOISE (US\$35). LURK ON THE SWLING POST FIRST.²

THE JARGON, TRANSLATED

DX — distant stations; the sport within the hobby. **QSL** — a card confirming you heard a station. **QRM / QRN** — man-made / natural interference. **Grey-line** — the dawn/dusk band where long-distance propagation goes freakishly efficient. **Waterfall** — the scrolling spectrum display on an SDR.⁵

THE SCEPTIC — "IT'S ALL ON THE INTERNET NOW"

The hobby is unusually honest about its own decline, and the case against it is real. Wikipedia's own entry concedes there are "few practical reasons to buy a shortwave radio" when the stations are online; WebSDR makes owning an antenna optional; and in a noisy flat the first experience is often disappointing, the noise floor up 30 to 40 decibels.⁶ The community's own rebuttal is the "undead" thesis: broadcasting is dying, but *listening plus decoding plus prepping* is alive — the bands are "jammed" if you count utility, digital, pirate and ham traffic, and a receiver that needs no grid is worth owning for the one week the grid is gone.⁶

NEXT DESCENTS — YOU PICK THE NEXT RABBIT HOLE

Fountain pens — inks, nibs and grail pens, where a S\$3 Pilot and a S\$500 Nakaya share a page and "just one more ink" is the running joke.

Coral reef aquariums — not keeping fish but running a miniature ocean, where a decimal point of alkalinity can erase a year's work.

FPV drones — solder your own quad, fly it through gaps at 100 mph in goggles, and crash it a lot; maker, pilot and videographer fused into one.

SOURCES 1 "The antenna is the most important part" + SNR over raw signal; magnetic loops for urban noise rejection — Airspy YouLoop ~US\$35, MLA-30+ US\$30–37, Bonito/W6LVP high end; Wellbrook ceased trading 2023 — rtl-sdr.com; radio-hobbyist.com; community shootouts. 2 Buy-once inflection ~US\$600 (Airspy HF+ Discovery + loop); starter kit ~US\$244 (V4 ~\$40 + HF+ Discovery \$169 + YouLoop \$35); lurk SWling Post / r/shortwave — this desk, from gear research. 3 Cutting edge — RTL-SDR V4 → V4L "Lite" (~14 May 2026); RX-888 MkII 64 MHz capture <US\$200; SDRconnect v1.0.9 (15 Jun 2026, third-party API); "no revolutionary radio" — rtl-sdr.com; SDRplay. 4 Singapore — receive-only needs no IMDA licence (transmitting framework only; verify — flagged); RAE suspended, FCC route via SARTS (S\$50/yr); HDB RFI documented between floors — imda.gov.sg; sarts.org.sg; HardwareZone forum (thread 5438047). 5 Glossary — DX/QSL/QRM/QRN/SINPO/grey-line/waterfall — Wikipedia (QSL card; SINPO; DXing); propagation references. 6 The sceptic — Wikipedia "few practical reasons to buy" (all online); WebSDR obviates antennas; broadcaster retreat; urban noise floor +30–40 dB; community rebuttal (bands "jammed" with utility/digital/pirate; grid-down value) — Wikipedia; RadioReference "SWL a Dying Hobby?"; London Shortwave / SWling Post.

FITNESS · THE COUNT AND THE DOSE

One Long Walk a Week Did What Three Shorter Ones Did

A randomised trial found that packing a week's brisk interval walking into a single 75-minute session cut body fat and lifted fitness about as much as splitting the same total time across three. The frequency you schedule matters less than the dose inside it — with caveats worth reading. General guidance, not medical advice.

The result is a small liberation with a large asterisk. In a randomised controlled trial of 315 adults with central obesity, run in Hong Kong over three years and published in *Nature Communications*, one group did all its brisk interval walking in a single weekly 75-minute session, another split the same 75 minutes across three sessions, and a control did neither. At 16 weeks, both walking groups had reduced adiposity and raised cardiorespiratory fitness by similar amounts against the control — frequency barely mattered, total dose did.¹ The lead investigator's framing was that once-weekly interval training "offers similar benefits and represents a practical exercise strategy." For a reader who already covered "Japanese walking" as a daily practice, this is the genuinely new twist: the calendar count is not the lever; the volume and intensity inside it are.¹

The asterisk is who was studied. The population was sedentary and carrying central obesity — not a mid-

40s optimiser who already trains — so the honest read is permission to consolidate on a bad week, not a ceiling that says one session is optimal.² A single long session raises injury and adherence questions the trial's supervised setting masked, and the study shows a fat-loss and fitness floor, not the maximal dose for VO_2max , muscle or longevity in someone already fit.² Run by heart rate on a Whoop or Oura, the intervals are trivial to structure — brisk at the top, easy on the recovery. But hold the finding at its true size: minimum effective dose is not maximal dose. General guidance, not medical advice.

315

ADULTS WITH CENTRAL OBESITY IN THE HONG KONG TRIAL. ONE 75-MINUTE WEEKLY WALK MATCHED THREE 25-MINUTE ONES ON FAT LOSS AND FITNESS AT 16 WEEKS. A DOSE STORY WEARING A FREQUENCY HEADLINE.¹

DOSE > FREQUENCY

NATURE COMMUNICATIONS

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

THE CHATTER — THE LONGEVITY TIMELINE ARGUES THREE WAYS

Three things the discourse is chewing on this month, each a useful counterweight. First, "sleep now outranks diet and exercise as a longevity lever" — the same claim that anchors this issue's Family desk ([p12](#)).³ Second, a Stanford-cited push to raise protein for the over-40s from the RDA's 0.8 to 1.0–1.2 grams per kilo, to offset the roughly 1%-a-year muscle loss after 40 (verify the exact citation).³ Third, and the sharpest counter to a single-modality walking study: a Harvard analysis of more than 111,000 adults over 30 years found exercise *variety*, at matched total volume, was linked to a 19% lower risk of premature death.⁴ Mix it up, in other words — the opposite lesson from the same evidence base.

THE SCEPTIC — DON'T READ AN OBESITY TRIAL AS TRAINING ADVICE

The disciplined caveat is population transfer. *r/fitness* perennially warns against reading results from sedentary, at-risk cohorts as programming for the already-active, and this trial is exactly that — a 16-week fat-loss and fitness floor, not a longevity or hypertrophy result.² "Same total minutes, of course the outcomes match" is a fair deflation: this is a dose story dressed as a frequency story. The falsifier for the exciting headline is a trial in a trained, younger cohort that fails to reproduce equivalence — or that finds a single weekly session raises injury rates over time. Consolidate when life demands it; don't build a programme on it. Not medical advice.

SOURCES 1 Parco Siu et al. (HKUMed), *Nature Communications* (s41467-025-68149-7) — RCT, 315 adults with central obesity, Hong Kong, ~2021–2024; one 75-min weekly brisk interval walk ≈ three 25-min sessions on adiposity/fitness at 16 weeks; frequency less decisive than dose — [nature.com](#); [hku.hk](#) press release. Media wave early Aug 2026 (ScienceDaily 1 Aug; LadBible 4 Aug); paper posted online early 2026 — date ambiguity flagged. 2 Caveats — sedentary/central-obesity cohort, 16-week fat-loss/fitness floor (not VO_2max /muscle/longevity), injury/adherence questions; "minimum effective ≠ maximal dose" — study limitations; *r/fitness*. General guidance, not medical advice. 3 Longevity discourse — "sleep outranks diet/exercise" (2026 round-ups, single-sourced); Stanford-cited protein 1.0–1.2 g/kg for over-40s (verify) — SUCCESS; Yahoo Health. 4 Harvard/BMJ Medicine (Jan 2026), Nurses' Health + HPFU, n>111,000, 30 yrs — highest exercise variety linked to ~19% lower premature-death risk at matched volume — [hsph.harvard.edu](#).

THE DIARY · THE DATED AGENDA

One Alarm to Set This Morning, Then an October Worth Booking Flights For

BIGBANG's general sale drops today, Thursday, ahead of a Kallang October that stacks an F1 weekend and a sold-out December. In Japan, the autumn art calendar and the foliage windows reward booking the rooms now. Lock the tickets before the diaries fill.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

- 13 AUG**
★ BIGBANG — 〈XX: COSMOS〉 20th-anniv tour
 NATIONAL STADIUM, 17 OCT · GENERAL SALE TODAY 10AM, TICKETMASTER SG · S\$158–498, CHEAP CATS FIRST
- 9–11 OCT**
★ F1 Singapore GP
 MARINA BAY · PADANG: THE KILLERS, LANA DEL REY, JJ LIN, JANET JACKSON · SEVERAL CATEGORIES SOLD OUT
- 17–22 DEC**
★ BTS — World Tour 'ARIRANG'
 NATIONAL STADIUM, 4 NIGHTS · SOLD OUT — VERIFIED RESALE ONLY (CONFIRMED; CORRECTING AN EARLIER MISS)
- 27 OCT**
ROSÉ — ROSETOPIA Asia Tour
 THE STAR THEATRE · GENERAL SALE OPENED 4 AUG · THEATRE-SCALE, SMALL INVENTORY
- 14–16 AUG**
F♦FOREVER — 1st World Tour
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · THIS WEEKEND · S\$178–398, ON SALE NOW
- to Dec**
Harry Potter: Visions of Magic
 IMMERSIVE WAND EXPERIENCE · FAMILY (GOOD FOR AN 11-YO) · BOOK ANYTIME, SCHOOL-HOLIDAY FILLER
- 3 OCT**
ITZY — world tour
 SINGAPORE INDOOR STADIUM · CLASHES WITH THE F1/WEEKND WEEKEND, PLAN AROUND IT
- 11 DEC**
My Little Pony: Floral Fantasy
 GARDENS BY THE BAY · FROM 11 DEC, TIMED TO THE DECEMBER SCHOOL HOLIDAYS · FAMILY
- all year**
Children's Season 2026
 20+ MUSEUMS · HANDS-ON KIDS' PROGRAMMING · THE RELIABLE SCHOOL-HOLIDAY EVERGREEN

JAPAN & THE REGION

PLAN THE FLIGHTS

- to 8 Oct**
★ teamLab Borderless — new "Flow" series
 AZABUDAI HILLS, TOKYO · FAMILY + CULTURE ANCHOR · TIMED ENTRY SELLS OUT WEEKENDS, RESERVE BEFORE YOU FLY
- 28 Aug–25 Oct**
Ryuichi Sakamoto × Shiro Takatani
 AZABUDAI HILLS GALLERY · IMMERSIVE INSTALLATION · SINGLE-SOURCED DATE, VERIFY ON BOOKING
- 29 Aug–6 Dec**
Minami Tada retrospective
 MOT, TOKYO · LIGHT-AND-MOVEMENT SCULPTURE · RUNS THE WHOLE AUTUMN WINDOW
- 1–3 Nov**
★ Koyo season + Meiji Jingu Culture Day
 TOKYO/NIKKO/HAKONE FOLIAGE PEAKS MID-OCT → LATE NOV · LOCK KOYO-SEASON ROOMS NOW, THEY FILL EARLY
- to 9 Sep**
Van Gogh — first Japan showing in a decade
 ABENO HARUKAS, OSAKA · IF THE TRIP IS A KANSAI ONE
- 13–27 Sep**
★ Grand Sumo — Autumn Basho (Aki)
 RYŌGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · 15 DAYS · A GENUINE BUCKET-LIST DAY OUT, TICKETS GO FAST
- 21–22 Nov**
Hachiōji Ginkgo Festival
 TOKYO · THE GINKGO-AVENUE PEAK · A FREE, FAMILY-FRIENDLY AUTUMN SET-PIECE
- TBC '26**
Coldplay — Light Up the Globe (Asia)
 TOKYO/OSAKA/SEOUL/BANGKOK/SINGAPORE ANNOUNCED · CITY DATES & ON-SALES TBC — VERIFY BEFORE PLANNING

PLANNING NOTES — TIMING, SELL-OUTS, FAMILY-FIT

BIGBANG's general sale is live this morning; the cheaper categories go first, so decide before the queue forms. BTS is fully sold — use only verified resale, and treat any other source with caution. Book the F1 remainder now before further category sell-outs, and note that the Weeknd, ROSÉ and ITZY all stack into the same October fortnight, so a single trip can catch several. In Japan, the September Grand Sumo basho and the teamLab timed-entry slots reward booking weeks ahead, and koyo-season hotels in Tokyo, Nikko and Hakone fill early — lock the rooms before the foliage forecasts firm up. For the eleven-year-old, Harry Potter: Visions of Magic, the December My Little Pony run, and the year-round Children's Season are the safe school-holiday picks.¹

SOURCES 1 Singapore — BIGBANG (XX: COSMOS) (National Stadium, 17 Oct; general sale 13 Aug 10am, S\$158–498) — MissLobang; Ticketmaster SG. F1 Singapore GP (9–11 Oct; Padang: The Killers, Lana Del Rey, JJ Lin, Janet Jackson; several cats sold out) — singaporegp.sg; Time Out SG. BTS 'ARIRANG' (17/19/20/22 Dec, SOLD OUT) — Live Nation SG; STB. ROSÉ ROSETOPIA (Star Theatre, 27 Oct, on sale 4 Aug) — BookMyShow SG. F♦FOREVER (Indoor Stadium, 14–16 Aug). Japan — teamLab Borderless "Flow" (to 8 Oct); Ryuichi Sakamoto × Takatani (28 Aug–25 Oct, single-sourced); Minami Tada (MOT, 29 Aug–6 Dec); Meiji Jingu Culture Day (1–3 Nov) + koyo; Van Gogh (Abeno HARUKAS, to 9 Sep) — teamlab.art; JapanTravel; Artizon. Region — Coldplay Asia leg dates TBC (verify) — coldplay.com.

THE TABLE • SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

A Los Angeles Pasta Chef Comes Home, and a Tokyo Bakery Lands on Orchard

This fortnight's openings run from the genuinely loved to the too-new-to-call. One is a homecoming with silky handmade pasta under S\$20; two are Japan and character-IP imports whose reception hasn't formed yet. Where it's early, we say so.

The one to book is a homecoming. **Tavola Aperta**, at Plaza Singapura (opened 3 July), is chef Mark Tan's return after three years at Los Angeles's acclaimed Felix Trattoria — handmade pasta priced under S\$20, sourdough pizza on a 72-hour dough, a Linguine al Limone and a white ragù bolognese over pappardelle that reads as a homage to Felix's "Vecchia Scuola."¹ This is the fortnight's consensus win, not a divisive one: HungryGoWhere, The Ranting Panda and Alvinology align on silky fresh pasta and restrained, confident cooking at approachable prices — most plates under S\$30, casual mall setting, reservable on Chope.¹ After a run of destination omakase and hype-driven launches, an unfussy pasta room that simply cooks well is the most re-tellable thing on the list.

Rituel, at Takashimaya on Orchard, is the first overseas flagship of the Tokyo bakery-café — viennoiserie plus all-day French café fare, afternoon tea and dinner service. It suits this reader as a Japan import, but the honest label is too-new-to-judge: reception hasn't formed in local media, and the notable thing so far is the pedigree and the launch-period pastry-counter crowds, not a verdict.² And for the eleven-year-old, **Pop Bakery by POP MART** at Resorts World Sentosa (opened 30 July) is the pick — the brand's first Southeast Asia bakery, a two-storey

flagship of some 45 character pastries (Labubu, Molly, Dimoo) from S\$5 to S\$32. The coverage frames it as spectacle over substance — "too cute to eat," queues for anything Labubu-adjacent — a family and IP destination rather than a culinary one, so go weekday off-peak to dodge the lines.³

A note on how to read this page. The fortnight's other openings skew to imports still finding their feet — a run of Japan and character-IP arrivals whose crowds, for now, measure novelty rather than the kitchen. That is the recurring shape of a mall-and-Orchard opening season: pedigree and queues arrive first, the settled verdict weeks later. When a room is genuinely too new to call, this desk says so and re-pegs on the reviews rather than borrowing the launch buzz as a rating. The one exception this fortnight — the place that earns the trip on the cooking, not the concept — is Tavola Aperta.¹

<S\$20

MOST HANDMADE-PASTA PLATES AT TAVOLA APERTA — A FELIX TRATTORIA ALUMNUS'S HOMECOMING, AND THE FORTNIGHT'S GENUINELY-LOVED OPENING RATHER THAN A HYPED ONE. RESERVABLE ON CHOPE; GO FOR THE LINGUINE AL LIMONE.¹

TAVOLA APERTA • LOVED

RITUEL • TOO NEW

POP BAKERY • FAMILY

THE SCEPTIC — SPECTACLE ISN'T A REVIEW, AND "NEW" ISN'T "GOOD"

Two honesty flags for the list. Pop Bakery is an IP destination whose queues measure hype, not the plate — the food is, by the coverage's own account, secondary to the character shapes, so treat it as an outing for the daughter, not a dining recommendation.³ And Rituel is genuinely too new to judge: a buzzy Japan import with a strong name is a reason to visit, not a verdict on the pastry — reception hasn't settled, and a department-store launch crowd is not a review.² The one that earns the trip on the cooking, not the concept, is Tavola Aperta. Where a place has only just opened, "too new to call" is the honest line — and we'll re-peg on the settled reviews.

SOURCES 1 Tavola Aperta (Plaza Singapura, opened 3 Jul 2026) — chef Mark Tan (ex-Felix Trattoria, LA); handmade pasta under S\$20, 72-hr sourdough pizza, Linguine al Limone, white ragù; warm consensus — HungryGoWhere; The Ranting Panda; Alvinology. 2 Rituel (Takashimaya, Orchard) — first overseas flagship of the Tokyo bakery-café; viennoiserie + all-day French café; too new to judge — local coverage; flagged. 3 Pop Bakery by POP MART (Resorts World Sentosa, opened 30 Jul 2026) — first SEA bakery, ~45 character pastries S\$5–32; "spectacle over substance," family/IP destination — SETHLUI; TheSmartLocal. Not halal-certified (unverified). Where too new, "too new to call" — re-peg on settled reviews.

THE UNDERCURRENT · JAPAN

The Company You Can Carry

In the world's oldest, most single-person society, grown adults have turned plush toys into portable companions — carried to cafés and shrines, tucked into hotel beds, photographed everywhere with their owners' faces kept out of frame. It has a name, nuikatsu, and a fast-growing economy behind it. The West hasn't written it up yet. It will.

The photograph gives the game away. A small plush toy sits on a café table, dressed, posed beside a parfait — and the person who brought it is nowhere in the frame. This is *nuikatsu* (ぬい活), a contraction of *nuigurumi*, plush doll, and *katsudō*, activity: the practice of carrying, dressing, posing and photographing a stuffed toy as a companion and a social-media stand-in, the plush acting as an avatar so the owner never has to appear.¹ The term is old — it dates to around 2012 — but by Google's own trend data it barely registered until 2022, then surged through 2025, when it was nominated to the top thirty of Japan's U-Can New Words and Buzzwords Award, the country's official marker that a niche behaviour has gone mainstream.¹ Its leaders are Gen Z women, but by every trend account participation now runs from teenagers to people in their sixties and beyond.

The money is real and rising. Tokyo Shoko Research found that the combined sales of 34 plush-toy-related companies grew from ¥50.4 billion in 2021 to ¥84.9 billion in 2025 — roughly 1.7 times in four years — though the honest caveat is that this is aggregate corporate revenue, not a clean "nuikatsu market" figure.² A survey by the SHIBUYA109 lab, of 507 women aged 15 to 24, found that 80% had engaged in nuikatsu, that 70.3% said owning a plush felt "like carrying an *omamori*" — a good-luck charm — and that about half described it as "a healing presence." (The sample is small, young and Shibuya-skewed, and "experience" is a generous bar; hold the figure at its true weight.)³ What the numbers describe is not a toy craze. It is a comfort economy — and comfort, in this society, is a growth sector.

A small plush sits on a café table, dressed, posed beside a parfait — and the person who brought it is nowhere in the frame.

1.7×

GROWTH IN THE COMBINED REVENUE OF 34 PLUSH-TOY COMPANIES, ¥50.4BN (2021) TO ¥84.9BN (2025), PER TOKYO SHOKO RESEARCH. AGGREGATE CORPORATE REVENUE, NOT A PURE "NUIKATSU" FIGURE — BUT THE DIRECTION IS UNMISTAKABLE.²

What are people actually buying, and why? The trend accounts, and the owners quoted in them, keep returning to three self-descriptions. The first is *iyashi* — healing, comfort, "a presence." The second is fashion: the plush as a bag charm, a styling accessory that also happens to be soft. The third, and the sharpest cultural signal, is the plush as a stand-in for the self — a body double you photograph in your place, so that a life can be documented online without a face in it.³ It is worth sitting with how strange, and how legible, that last one is. In a culture that prizes not imposing on others, a plush lets you be present without demanding to be seen; it carries the intimacy and absorbs the exposure.

THE READ — AN OMAMORI YOU CAN DRESS

The most repeated framing among young owners is protective, not playful: the plush as a good-luck charm you carry, an *omamori* with a face. That the object is described in the register of a shrine talisman rather than a toy is the tell — this is not childishness resurfacing, but a very old function (portable reassurance) migrating into a very new form (the social-media avatar). Note the language before you judge the behaviour.³

SOURCES 1 *Nuikatsu* (ぬい活) — *nuigurumi* + *katsudō*; carrying/posing/photographing plush as companion and avatar, faces kept off-frame; term ~2012, surged from 2022, nominated to U-Can 2025 New Words & Buzzwords top-30 — Scripting Japan (Wesley Robertson); *kanpai-japan*; *toy-people.com*. 2 Tokyo Shoko Research — 34 plush-toy companies' combined sales ¥50.4bn (2021) → ¥84.9bn (2025), ~1.7×; aggregate corporate revenue, not a pure market figure — flagged — via Yahoo News (Takahisa Sunaoshi) / *toy-people.com*. 3 SHIBUYA109 lab survey (press release 25 Feb 2025), n=507 women 15–24 — 80% engaged in nuikatsu, 70.3% "like carrying an *omamori*," ~half "a healing presence"; small, young, Shibuya-skewed sample — flagged — SHIBUYA109 lab; *Fashionsnap*.

Follow the money out of the survey and into the world, and the ecosystem is startlingly built out. Toyoko Inn, the business-hotel chain, rolled out an "Overnight with Your Plushie Plan" — pyjamas and a made-up mini-bed for the toy — expanding from a single test in Osaka to more than 55 locations.¹ In June 2026 a shrine opened in Kyoto offering prayer and memorial rites for worn-out plushies. Dedicated nuikatsu cafés let people dine beside their plush "without feeling self-conscious," and a parallel service economy of plush "hospitals" for repairs and plush spas for cleaning has grown up alongside them.¹ These vivid details are single-sourced and drawn from the Japanese-language and specialist press, so treat each as reported rather than audited — but the pattern across them is unmistakable: an entire commercial layer now exists to service a relationship between a person and an object.

The behaviour is not whimsy, and reading it as cute misses the argument. Nuikatsu is a canary for monetised atomisation, and three forces converge on

it. First, the solo society: as of 2026 about 34% of Japanese households are single-person, a figure projected to reach roughly 44% by 2050, and a government survey found nearly 39% of the population feels lonely — Japan has had a Minister of Loneliness since 2021.² A portable, non-judgemental companion is not a gimmick in that context; it is emotional infrastructure. Second, the maturation of oshikatsu, the fan-spending economy: the plush is the "oshi" you can hold, feed a café parfait, tuck into a hotel bed — fandom graduating from concerts and merch into an everyday attachment technology.³ Third, and most telling for the platform age, the face-off-plush-on photograph is a quiet grammar of presence without surveillance — a way to be visible online without exposing yourself.

The plush is the oshi you can hold — fandom graduating from concerts and merch into an everyday attachment technology.

The comfort economy, four years

combined sales, 34 plush-toy companies (¥bn)



A Meridian chart. Combined revenue of 34 plush-toy companies. Source: Tokyo Shoko Research, via Yahoo News / toy-people.com.

A FRICTION POINT — WHEN THE RITUAL MET THE TABLE

The comfort ritual has already collided with public etiquette. In May 2026 a British-style Tokyo pub, Old Arrow, posted on X asking patrons not to place plushies or merchandise on dining tables — citing space, hygiene and the drift from dining to photography — and set off a manners debate about where private comfort ends and shared space begins.¹ It is the kind of small, telling conflict that appears when a niche behaviour scales into the mainstream: not a scandal, but a society negotiating, in real time, how much room to make for the company people now carry.

SOURCES 1 Commercial ecosystem — Toyoko Inn "Overnight with Your Plushie Plan" (55+ locations); Kyoto plush shrine with memorial rites (Jun 2026); nuikatsu cafés (e.g. Little Lou's, Tokyo); plush "hospitals"/spas; Old Arrow pub table-etiquette debate (May 2026) — SoraNews24; Unseen Japan; single-sourced, reported not audited — flagged. 2 The solo society — ~34% single-person households (2026), projected ~44% by 2050; ~39% feel lonely; Minister of Loneliness since 2021 — Nippon.com; government surveys. 3 Oshikatsu maturation — plush as the holdable "oshi," an everyday attachment technology; note.com/arukt "推しの分身" (avatar of one's oshi) framing — note.com; DEJAPAN; toy-people.com.

Japan has reached for this before. In moments of economic anxiety and social atomisation it repeatedly produces portable, non-judgemental companions, and nuikatsu sits at the newest end of a long line. The Tamagotchi of 1996–97 was a recession-era digital pet, care-as-play you kept in your pocket; nuikatsu is its analogue, low-tech descendant. The 1990s "iyashi" — healing — boom, and the global rise of Hello Kitty and kawaii, which the scholar Sharon Kinsella read as "cute" functioning as comfort and gentle regression through the Lost Decade, is the cultural precedent. Sony's AIBO of 1999 and the companion robots that followed are the high-tech branch of the same impulse.¹ Nuikatsu is that lineage's newest node: cheaper, softer, and native to social media. The through-line is not that Japan loves toys. It is that Japan keeps engineering intimacy, in whatever medium the decade offers, around a loneliness it has named and staffed a ministry to fight.

Which is why this belongs in a MERIDIAN before it belongs in the *Financial Times*. We ran the under-the-radar test by name: none of the New York Times, the BBC, Reuters or the FT has run a feature on nuikatsu. What they have covered is adjacent but different — Japan's companion robots and love dolls for loneliness, not plush.² The coverage that exists sits in exactly the tier the Undercurrent hunts: SoraNews24, Unseen Japan, Fodor's, and — the closest to the mainstream — Nikkei Asia, the Japan-owned business press. So the honest label is "warm," not ice-cold: it is thoroughly real, thoroughly documented in the Japanese press, and one slow news week away from a Western "Life & Arts" write-up.² When it lands, remember you read it here first.

The argument closes on the issue's spine. All fortnight the theme has been the gap between the number we watch and the thing that moves — the inflation print that soothed while gold rose on fear, the screens parents fear while sleep does the work, the frequency we schedule while the dose decides.³ Nuikatsu is that gap rendered in felt and thread. The visible signal is a cute photograph and a rising sales chart; the thing it actually measures is harder — what the market for human connection can no longer supply, priced and packaged and carried to a café. When a society's fastest-growing consumer ritual is buying companionship you can hold, the product is telling you something the survey can't. Read the object, not the smile.

Nuikatsu is the issue's spine in felt and thread: the visible signal is a cute photograph; the thing it measures is what connection can no longer supply.

And it is exportable, which is why it matters beyond Japan. The demographic pressures that produced nuikatsu — shrinking households, deferred or forgone partnership, a platform culture that rewards presence but punishes exposure — are not uniquely Japanese; they are simply furthest along there. Japan is the country that reaches this stage first and builds the product first, so its comfort economy is a preview of consumption patterns other aged, atomised, online societies will grow into. Watch what gets monetised at the edges of connection, because the edges are where the next mainstream forms. The plush on the café table is not a Japanese curiosity. It is a leading indicator.³

ON THE DESK'S WATCHLIST — TWO RUNNERS-UP WE HELD

Two other Asia-Pacific undercurrents nearly ran this fortnight, logged here so the reader sees the shortlist. In Vietnam, a July-2025 redrawing of the map from 63 provinces to 34 has triggered a speculative land lottery — towns promoted to administrative centres seeing transaction values leap, demoted former capitals softening — a policy pen-stroke turned into an asset. In Australia, for the first time about half of 18-to-29-year-olds say they would move to the regions, colliding with sub-1% regional vacancy rates: a housing-crisis inversion of the retiree "sea-change." Both are warmer in the Western press than nuikatsu; both are worth a later descent.⁴

SOURCES 1 Historical precedent — Tamagotchi (1996–97) as recession-era pocket companion; 1990s "iyashi" boom and kawaii-as-comfort, Sharon Kinsella's reading of "cute" through the Lost Decade; Sony AIBO (1999) and companion robots — Kinsella, scholarship on kawaii; general histories. 2 Under-the-radar check — NYT/BBC/Reuters/FT: no feature on nuikatsu (they cover companion robots / love dolls, not plush); existing coverage in SoraNews24, Unseen Japan, Fodor's, Nikkei Asia ("warm," not ice-cold) — searched by name; reported honestly. 3 Issue spine — the gap between the watched number and the driver (Macro p14; Family p12; Fitness p18) — editorial synthesis. 4 Held runners-up — Vietnam's 63 → 34 province merger (1 Jul 2025) and the resulting land-price surge; Australia's Gen Z regional-migration shift vs sub-1% vacancy — Rest of World / regional press; The Conversation. Warmer in Western coverage than nuikatsu; logged for a later descent.

The hobby on page fifteen is the whole issue in miniature. Turn the dial and you get static — a band the broadcasters abandoned, a floor of man-made hum — and the entire craft is the discipline of pulling one true signal out of it. That is the week's real instruction. Markets heard a mild inflation print and reached for the fear trade anyway; parents watch the screen and miss the sleep; a country's growth doubled and it felt nothing. The number is not the news. The signal is what changed, and it usually arrives quietly, buried in the noise, audible only if you have learned to tune. Read the footnotes. Trust the antenna, not the volume.

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CONSOLIDATED SOURCES

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